THE CAUSES OF THE SECOND ANGLO-BURMESE WAR

The Treaty of Yandabo (1826) ended the first Anglo-Burmese war that left the British in possession of Arakan and Tenasserim and established diplomatic and commercial relations between the British and the Burmese. Over the course of the next few years a succession of protocol, border, and political issues created tension between the British and the Burmese.

By the early 1830s King Bagyidaw had descended into madness and was replaced by a regency consisting of the queen, Mè Nu, her brother, Salinmyoza, and three of the king's five brothers, princes Tharrawaddy (his full brother) and half brothers Thibaw and Kanaung, that ruled as a coalition. Behind the scenes Mè Nu and Salinmyoza schemed to gain control of the throne. Mè Nu had her brother raised to princely status and was made the de facto head of state. Mè Nu and her brother usurped control of the throne by taking control of the royal patronage network and placed their supporters throughout the kingdom. The court power struggle came to a head on February 21, 1837, when Salinmyoza ordered the arrest of Tharrawaddy's sister, the Pagan princess, on suspicion of hoarding arms. Fearing that he would be next, Tharrawaddy fled the capital to Shwebo, the seat of the Konbaung dynasty, where he gathered support and eventually raised an army. Initially opposed to open rebellion, Tharrawaddy became an instrument of his follower's discontent and their opposition to Mè Nu and her brother. Tharrawaddy's eldest daughter, a highly respected astrologer, declared the rebellion's success to be ordained in the stars.

By March 1837, Tharrawaddy had defeated the dispirited royal forces and was advancing toward Ava when several of Bagyidaw's closest advisors sued for peace. Tharrawaddy accepted the offer on the condition that the royalists hand over a list of 14 advisors. The royalists complied with the request and surrendered in early April 1837. In late April, Tharrawaddy executed the three ministers responsible for ordering the arrest of the Pagan princess. Shortly thereafter Tharrawaddy announced that Bagyidaw had abdicated the throne and his elevation to the throne.

King Tharrawaddy Min (r. ca. 1837–1845) refused to accept the terms of the Treaty of Yandabo as binding. Relations between the British and the Burmese slowly deteriorated. Successive British residents at court: Colonel Henry Burney, Colonel Richard Benson, and McLeod, allowed under the